Emperor sent them on a pilgrimage to Makkah.' It is possible that as incendiary talks began in the intimacy of the ibadat khana, Akbar also wished to reassure his more orthodox populace of his being a true Muslim monarch. At the same time, Akbar was sending an emissary to Goa armed with money and gifts, always keen to learn about 'the curiosities and rarities' of different places, with instructions to bring back 'the wonderful productions' that the Portuguese may have brought with them to Goa.

The women, meanwhile, were sent off in a magnificent cavalcade and orders were sent to 'the great Amirs, the officers of every territory, the guardians of the passes, the watchmen of the borders, the river-police, and the harbour-masters' to make the journey of this chosen party as smooth as possible. The only senior Timurid woman not to be included in this party was Hamida Banu Begum, who remained at Fatehpur Sikri to keep vigil over her son, the Padshah.

That there was still considerable apprehension about the trouble the Portuguese might cause for the ladies at Surat can be inferred from the fact that Qulich Khan, the Governor of Surat, was deputed to attend to them there. Qulich Khan was familiar with Portuguese dealings and was not reassured when he reached the port city. Moosvi has examined a farman which showed that following Qulich Khan's appraisal, Akbar was 'unnerved, and wrote to his "Esteemed Mother"…to consider her journey to Surat as equivalent to hajj and defer the voyage at least for a year. He openly expressed his fear for a blow to the honour of the Imperial Family, and his own great pain, if something happened to the party at the hands of the Portuguese.' But Gulbadan and the ladies had not come so far on the journey of their lives to be put off by fear of the loathed 'firangis' and a cartaz was finally obtained.

While the hajj party was at Surat, they would have received sad news of the death of an old ally of the harem from the days of the early forays into Hindustan. One of their number, Bibi Saruqad, was now widowed, for Munim Khan khankhanan had just died, far from his home and his family, in Bengal. 'He rendered his account to the guardian of Paradise,' was Badauni's truculent assessment, 'or to the guardian of Hell (God knows!)'. After the surrender of Daud Khan, Munim Khan had made the disastrous decision to shift the seat of the government from Tanda to the ancient city of Gaur. But the river Ganga had changed her course and now the rushing river had become a stagnant, maleficent backwater which bred diseases,